

plethora of filters and effects under the hood. These are especially fun to use when chatting with friends, or younger children. To apply these effects, in a video call, tap the Filters or Effects button on the right side and you can choose from the array of options available.



MAKE DUO CALLS FROM THE DIALER

On Android devices (most of them), you can directly make Duo video calls or even voice calls directly from the dialer application without ever having to open up Duo. First, open the dialer application on your Android phone, then navigate to your contacts and simply tap the contact's photo. Here, you will be given the option to make a regular call or send a text, and also make a Duo video or voice call.



GOOGLE HANGOUTS

Google does have a very

confusing litany of options for socialising, however, it seems like they've narrowed it down to two – Google Duo, which we addressed above, and Google Hangouts, which branches into Hangouts Meet (or simply Google Meet) and Hangouts Chat. We take it back, it's still confusing. To simplify this, Hangouts Chat is essentially the traditional Hangouts with chatting, voice calling and video calling options, while Hangouts Meet is an official business video calling solution with support for 250 person meetings, real-time captions and more.



SHARE YOUR SCREEN

It is relatively simple to share your device screen

when using Google Hangouts. When you're in a video call simply click the three dots on the top-right corner of the screen. From the list of options, select the 'share screen' option. Now you can choose how you want to share the screen – you can either share the entire screen or just individual windows. Once you've chosen, simply select share.



ADD ATTENDEES TO YOUR CALL

You can video call up to 250 participants on Google Hangouts simultaneously if you are subscribed to G Suite. It can be quite arduous to manually type everyone's contact details in the participant list, so instead you can simply generate a web URL which will allow individuals to join the call. Simply click on the video call button when you open Hangouts in the browser and then click on the Invite button. Here, find and click on Copy Link to Share. You will have generated a link to the video conference.



SEE PARTICIPANTS IN A GRID VIEW

In case you are particularly taken by Zoom's tiled view, but you still prefer using Google Hangouts and you want something similar here, you can use a Chrome

extension called Google Meet Grid View. Simply head over to this URL (<https://dgit.in/GridView>) and add the extension to your Google Chrome. Now, all the participants in your Hangouts video call will be neatly arranged in a tiled fashion similar to Zoom.



BONUS TIPS FOR MISCELLANEOUS APPS

Here are some handy tips and tricks for other video calling apps that are used just as frequently by users around the world and also video calling in general.

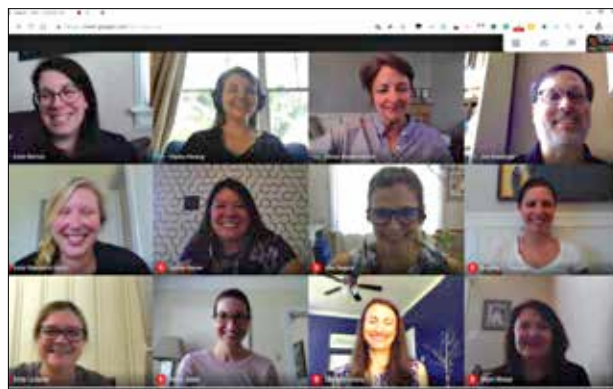
1. Ensure to check your video feed in advance in order to set yourself up in the right position, ensure that you have adequate lighting for the call, and also make sure that your microphone is working properly. You can do this on mobile by simply recording a selfie video and on PC, you can check your video using a Camera app and the microphone by using a Voice Recorder app.
2. Ensure that you wear headphones so that you can hear the participants clearly and can also be heard clearly by others. Also, keep the mute button handy and use it generously to avoid distracting others with coughing, background noises, or fidgeting.
3. Make sure that you are running the latest version of your video calling app at all times to avoid facing any compatibility issues while on call.
4. In Zoom, you can smooth out your appearance by finding and activating the 'Touch up my appearance'



The WFH model has made video calling apps more popular

option in the Video settings panel. This is quite useful during the lockdown since most people have unruly hair and may generally be unkempt.

5. In Houseparty, ensure to lock your room by hitting the padlock icon at the bottom of the screen. This will prevent random people from joining your room and invading your privacy. You can also turn off Houseparty notifications by clicking on the smiley face on the top left of the screen and then clicking manage notifications. Simply choose the option to stop sending and receiving pesky alerts such as 'XXX is in the house'.
6. In apps such as Zoom, ensure to set up passwords for your meetings in order to make sure that only the people you want can attend the meeting. Zoom has also turned on default password protection.



Grid view in Google Hangouts